

Alone With God

Danny Boyle's 2007 science fiction epic *Sunshine* has all the trappings of science fiction spectacle – a vast expanse of outer space, beautiful solar landscapes, and a hero's journey by way of impressive technology. However, his direction and Alex Garland's script construct a philosophical Matryoshka doll with dimensions borne from antiquity, featuring recursive patterns and modes, metaphilosophical, metaphysical, and metaethical self-examination, and concentrated on its own telos; the film's events occur in a vague near-future, strangled by climate crisis, and a scientific mission intended to "solve" the crisis, known as Icarus, must dabble with untested nuclear science within a narrow margin of humility, faith, and sacrifice. The Earth's Sun, historically a symbol of the Gods and scientifically understood as the thing that engenders all life on Earth, is a dying star, and human civilization is threatened – unless, of course, science or men of science can solve the impending apocalypse without crossing the invisible moral boundaries of human capacity and knowledge. In the spirit of its ancestor, *2001: A Space Odyssey*, *Sunshine* seeks to articulate lines of cosmological and metaphysical inquiry, framed by ancient philosophy and futurisms, as we move beyond basic mastery of universal scientific truths, and characterizes the journey's participants as different ethical or moral frameworks. They embody the origins and evolution of philosophy and metaphysics and provide a re-examination of morality in the wake of the "Atomic Age". Perhaps, as a whole, the film symbolizes a new atomic moment, in which the bomb is no longer a symbol of scientific capacity for construction but of scientific capacity for construction, perhaps even a spiritual instrument. Boyle's emphasis on the Sun as a character lends itself to the overwhelming possibility that within the spiritual and philosophical dimensions presented here it is a symbol for god. The philosophical, spiritual, and ethical themes are reinterpretation of Greek and Greek-influenced philosophers and theologians, providing a

reexamination of antiquity applied to a modern problem. It is metaphilosophical in its reexamination and attempt to recontextualize future, theoretical events based on empirical, practical knowledge, and its emphasis on thematic and spiritual recursiveness highlights the necessity for re-examination and re-interpretation of philosophy, spirituality, and ethics due to the endless motion of time.

Most obvious among the endless layers is that the narrative is a reinterpretation of the Icarus myth, bound forever to notions of scientific hubris (or ego) and impatient excitement; here it is pro-human and pro-scientific technology, and attempts to redraw the lines of the myth's lessons appropriate to modern questions. Civilization's very existence is contingent on the successful detonation of a massive nuclear bomb; the extreme characterization of an antagonist like Pinbacker juxtaposed alongside the humanistic Capa and utilitarian Mace reinforce the role of science as a morally neutral or consequentialist instrument, all morality or consequence stemming from an intervention of man and contingent on his ego. Undoubtedly Oppenheimer did not want to kill millions with nuclear technology, but was so enamored of the science, he did not intervene in the violent machinations of men; this tension, as Susan Sontag describes, is "drawn as a split between technology, which is beneficent, and the errant individual will of a lone intellectual"¹. The film inevitably relies on the intervention of science to save civilization, however it presents it in Greek mythic form as a mirror to the repetitive lessons of the past, present, and future, and reinforces the role of wisdom and experience in science. Like its namesake, Icarus I does not achieve its end – Pinbacker, its captain, is more akin to the mythological figure, whose excitement and unrestraint is also his end as he reaches too closely toward the power and beauty of the Sun, consequently meeting a destructive end. As in the myth, there is a narrow margin in which the pro-scientific

¹ Sontag, Susan. "The Imagination of Disaster." p. 48.

technology (wisdom) and pro-human civilization (humility) messages can co-exist and collaborate to orchestrate some cosmological pivot, and thankfully there is a protagonist, a physicist – perhaps a nod to Daedalus, whose knowledge, experience, and respect of natural law was a means to survival in the myth – who falls within that narrow realm, and allowing the positive consequences of scientific technology to manifest. The conflict in the film is generated mostly by the fact the science in this case is untested, so without the supporting tenet of experience, they are forced to calculate theoretical risk and make decisions of faith, contingent on their humility and wisdom. Interestingly, the film celebrates faith, but it does not enforce any particular religious ideology – the protagonists eschew supernaturalism (embodied by the delusional Pinbacker), yet they are not wholly rationalist or in favor of pure secularism. From a cultural standpoint, it seems to skirt theistic tradition and embrace a vague pantheistic ideology, which allows for such paradoxes as “miracles of science” and portrays the universe with reverence, as an object of contemplation.

If the top layer of the film is reflective of some cultural tendency toward knowledge, spirituality, humanism, and humility, the next layer is likely where the spiritual and philosophical elements unfold further. As in the Greek tradition, philosophy, ethics, and spirituality are bound together as extensions of one another; for the sake of analysis, philosophy and ethics will be treated as one thick layer, and spirituality is at the innermost core. In its effort to navigate philosophical discourse using references from antiquity, it becomes a metaphilosophical Heideggerian exercise in allowing an external observation of the working of philosophical processes. Many of the characters can be identified as symbolic of certain philosophical modes of thought, and it is through them and their role in this re-imagined Greek myth that their philosophy reveals itself toward questions of modernity and civilization; this is nothing new in philosophy, as it informs itself with every new generation – maybe it is coincidence, but many of the philosophies present in the film show up at multiple points in time, stemming from ancient Greece. Heidegger and Thomas Aquinas, most

notably, can be traced through themes, and both revisited the works of Plato and Aristotle and reinterpreted their concepts for their time. Heidegger's version of existentialism (informed by situational ethics) is wholly represented by Capa; it is telling without telling that the only Earth characters we ever acknowledge are Capa's sister and niece. He is, at one point, so wrapped up in sending them the "perfect" message to them that he encroaches on Mace's time; it is implied this may be their last message to Earth. The revisitation of the message at the end, contextualized by Capa's sacrifice and bravery, and juxtaposed against the Sun's new brightness indicate a deeper purpose; he is not just some physicist with noble goals for humanity but impelled to action by a profound love for his family. They assign meaning and purpose to his life and death (for him), and he is able to peacefully face his nightmares knowing this. This philosophical influence goes as far back as the etymological origins – philo and sophy, love and wisdom, are the two things about Capa that make him able to successfully navigate the same traps as Icarus and execute a god-like maneuver without ego.

Some of the other crew take on more naturalistic modes of thought (implicated here as cynicism or in stark contrast to faith), while others cling to rationalism in the safety of their technological reality – Harvey becomes a victim of this when he succumbs to the harshness of space when Capa, Harvey, and Mace exit an airlock with only one space suit. Capa and Mace indicate some faith in possibility and intuitive reasoning, while Harvey is victimized by a narrow range of what he knows to be rational and possible (this is another way the Icarus myth reappears and changes; perhaps it is too reductive to rely only on wisdom and experience). Pinbacker is the epitome of supernaturalism, indicated somewhat literally as a hallucinatory figure, in blurry, rapid shots; he is so loosely attached to the "reality" we can identify, that he is more monster or magic than man. He is an extreme variation, philosophy tainted by a perverse spirituality and moral hedonism, the ultimate foil to both human life and the Sun (or, god). The film also explores the

four branches of philosophy – metaphysics, logic, epistemology, and axiology. By virtue of being a “science” fiction, it is natural to integrate logic and epistemology; logical reasoning is central to objective scientific truths (rather, the intrinsic qualities of the cosmos) and the pursuit of knowledge and truth forms the very heart of scientific study. It makes sense that so much of science fiction is then wrapped up in layers of philosophical messaging, although this film seems to reference the process as much as the theory. In fact, I could write a separate 10 pages examining the epistemology discourse in the film, so a summary list of modes will have to suffice for our sake; the film comments on divine revelation, authority, empiricism, intuition, rationalism, pragmatism, idealism, constructivism, and relativism to varying degrees. Most importantly here, though, is the fourth branch: axiology, or aesthetics and ethics.

Axiology concerns itself with ethics and beauty; there is no shortage of either. For all the ritual devotion and characterization given the Sun, the composition of frames encapsulating any heavenly body is reverential and soothing. Even though space is cruel and unforgiving in practice, having taken the lives of several Icarus crew members, it is portrayed as an objective beauty, a potentiality of immense joy and exhilaration, inasmuch as it gives life or snuffs it out violently. The ethical dimensions are vast; the use of the Icarus myth is not surprising as a vehicle for moral debate about man’s arrogance in science. However, unraveling the ethics of characters reveals that the film is not asking whether nuclear technology by itself is right or wrong, but asking men to engage in moral debate about their role surrounding such “god-like” science. There are discussions of normative ethics within the film, such as when Icarus II encounters the signal of Icarus I and the crew fractures over whether the risk is worth the detour – the meta-ethical aspects boil down to consequentialist ethics versus deontological ethics, but allows for variation within each framework. The consequentialists Mace and Capa are two ends of the same spectrum; Mace is utilitarian in his approach to the mission, frustrated by the detour of Icarus II, and frustrated by Capa’s seeming

self-absorption, as he wants to keep going onward without risk. Despite this, he later protects Capa, as he is the only one able to detonate the payload, because for him the goal is to utilize this nuclear technology to save the most people. He sacrifices himself violently for the mission, a pragmatist until the end. Capa is more an embodiment of situational ethics; his positioning as a figure adjacent to metaphysical cosmology and his core “purpose” (the love for his family) denote an ethical imperative to attain the “highest” form of love. The bomb is also treated as consequentialist – we have seen nuclear fission’s capacity for cataclysmic violence exercised in reality, but this film posits that its “wrongness” is a matter of consequence, not intent. Here it is a reminder for nuclear technology’s generative capacities; in reality it is a cleaner source of energy than fossil fuels, and here it is capable of igniting a dying star. The morality of nuclear technology is best described by Aquinas: “There is no problem from the fact that some men desire evil. For they desire evil only under the aspect of good, that is, insofar as they think it is good. Hence their intention primarily aims at the good, and only incidentally touches on the evil”²

The metaphysical aspects, where spiritual aspects blossom in unavoidable form, touch on Aristotle and Aquinas’ questions of metaphysical causality, their understanding of the relationship of science and religion (or, more broadly, spirituality), Platonic and Aristotelian notions of everything existing in fluid states (in motion) and Thomas Aquinas’ view that metaphysics is the inevitable next stage of rational science, a rung on the ladder of intellectual evolution; to this end, metaphysical cosmology is influential and implicated in the realm of physical cosmology – the protagonist is a physicist, and physics and the dynamics of the universe is explicitly the realm of physical cosmology. Even the heliocentric view of the universe, the fundamental science that allows this film to exist as a parallel reality, originated in the physical cosmology of ancient Greece. However, its Aristotelian and Thomist themes focus predominantly on the convergence of

² Litzinger, C.I. (trans.), *St. Thomas Aquinas: Commentary on the NICOMACHEAN ETHICS, Volume I.*

science, philosophy, and theology. Aquinas considered philosophy and theology as partners, which reconciles many of the film's ideas – reason, revelation, myth, metaphysics, and knowledge. Aristotle's considerations of god were less theistic than Aquinas or his contemporary Plato, theorizing god as an object of aspiration; in this way Capa and the positive attributes of the narrative and nuclear technology are driven by that aspiration, and in contrast, Pinbacker theorizes god as an object of pursuit and being. A deistic or pantheistic interpretation of the film allows for this aspiration, as science and the metaphysics of the universe seem to be the religion (again, the Sun as god) or the intermediary for religious contemplation as evidence of god. The rituals of the film do not hold up to rational justification; there is a Sun Room aboard each Icarus, a contemplative space that allows its occupants peaceful communion with the Sun's devastating, hypnotic solar flares and immense, hallucinatory heat. The characters are allowed to adjust the amount of light entering the room, and the two characters who most resemble religious fanatics in their Sun Room escapes are Dr Searle and Pinbacker, each increasing their exposure and communion with an insufferably destructive force. They succumb to their ritualistic devotion to the Sun, however Searle offers himself up as sacrifice in Icarus I's Sun Room, seemingly as a peaceful offering to the Sun god in order to secure the survival of his crewmembers, as their survivability increases with each crewmember's death (increased oxygen supply). Searle places the Sun at the center of his contemplations, regularly advising crew members to seek out its spiritual strangeness, and honors his worship with sacrifice; Pinbacker, however, takes as much as he can from the Sun without sacrifice, having gone mad with exposure. He does not submit as an instrument of worship, but attempts to play with the "fire of the gods"; he is the embodiment of hedonism and ethical egoism, and his sabotage hinges on his fanatical desire to be "the last man, alone with god".

It is also very possible to read him as a hallucination; he appears as they approach the Sun, an area of space we have not physically explored and may impact our perception of reality, and the

implications of the journey – both the fact they may die and also the survival of civilization depends on their untested science experiment – are a recipe for madness. In the past, it is indicated by a recording that he was severely burned, and possibly driven to madness, and Icarus II's first excursion aboard Icarus I offers suggestive evidence that the crew died together in the Sun Room, having exposed themselves to the maximum sunlight. In the present, he is initially presumed dead, the Sun Room graveyard evidence of group suicide, but Pinbacker's unseen sabotage implicates more sinister ends. After his reveal, he is shown in blurry, stretched shots, more a figure of horror³ than science fiction (especially because this is not the result of accidental science; this is very intentional scientific hubris). For the most part, his relationship to the familiar "reality" we comprehend is only suggested by the violence, dialogue, and character actions surrounding him. If he is a hallucination, perhaps he is the ethical and spiritual foil to the protagonists – they are under immense pressures, half the crew having succumbed to their neuroses, nightmares, or extremely fatalistic circumstances, and their faith in pushing onward to execute a conceptual mission from which they will not benefit anyway is the pinnacle embodiment of faith in the unknown and transcendent suspension of belief and rationality. When Cassie and Capa defeat Pinbacker, they are able to remove any remaining egotistical obstacle to execute their ultimate sacrifice to the Sun.

Returning to Aquinas and Thomist theological philosophy, the Sun here assumes the role of god upon a more exclusively spiritual (and more theistic) examination. Thomism also advocates for an analogous contextualization of god; divinity is, by extension of its "infiniteness" too much for the finite human mind to comprehend. The film literally does this, using space, the Sun, the protagonists and their actions, and nuclear technology to imply the existence of some spiritual

³ "In the horror films, we have the mad or obsessed or misguided scientist who pursues his experiments against good advice to the contrary, creates a monster or monsters, and is himself destroyed". Sontag, Susan. "The Imagination of Disaster". p. 45.

Other. As the Other is incomprehensibly vast and infinite, it can only be examined in the creations and manifestations of god. Aquinas may have inadvertently predicted science fiction media, as he noted “Spiritual truths are fittingly taught under the likeness of material things”⁴. His “quinque viae” or “five ways” are theological arguments that attempt to marry logic and deductive reasoning as a scientific means to understand spirituality (well, identify god); interestingly, they work in tandem with the narrative in supporting the position that the Sun is god and the protagonists and science are instruments of god. The sun is the unmoved mover, Aristotle’s primary cause for all other entities to be set in motion; it’s made abundantly clear that it is the instrument of life, or the orchestral conductor of the solar system, guiding motions of life within physically narrow margins. Capa’s faith in successfully reigniting the Sun is easily interpreted as an unwavering faith in a spiritual Other, and he knows he will not bear the fruits of his sacrifice, but intends to prove evidence of his faith anyway. His faith is ultimately restorative. The first cause argument actually can work without theistic implications, even in favor of the Big Bang, as it seeks to identify a finite pattern of causality that originates from something that is simultaneously not itself and not nothing. The argument of contingency, first posited by Aristotle, holds that there must be a source of meaning in the universe’s existence – why does it exist at all – and that source of meaning cannot be infinitely regressive. Again, that can be found in the Heideggerian existentialism of Capa’s purpose; love is the source of meaning, and aspiring to walk in a “higher” love with others is implicitly wound with notions of god’s love. The fourth way is essentially theological interpretation of perfection; argument of degree follows, paraphrasing Aquinas, “if...a common note (is found) in several objects, it must be because some one cause has brought it about in them”⁵. Implicit in the film’s portrayal of degrees of goodness, altruism, knowledge, and faith is

⁴ St. Thomas Aquinas, [Summa Theologica](#) I, Q. I, Art. 9.

⁵ Aquinas, Thomas, “Reasons in Proof of the Existence of God, 1270”. *The Library of Original Sources*. Vol. V: The Early Medieval World, pp. 359-363.

indication of an invisible scale upon which rests the maximum embodiment of perfection: god. The degrees by which our protagonists achieve their purpose and goal rests upon the degree to which they aspire to live in god's image (or inadvertently embody god's love). Aquinas also believed men were instruments of god, and their usefulness as an instrument here is highly dependent on the nature of their god-like aspirations, which are celebrated (love, wisdom) or demonized (egoism, fanaticism) in the film. The fifth way is most important, as it has already been woven into modern science as a dimension of creationism and intelligent design. The teleological argument posits that the complexity, scope, and scale of science and the universe is evidence of some intelligent, divine Other. This is where science and spirituality truly converge, perhaps allowing that the antiquated notions of heavenly bodies and "the heavens" were more aligned with a full integration of science and spirituality. It allows science to be an instrument of spirituality, both working in tandem for a more ethical, intellectual, and loving future. In the spirit of science fiction, the future setting of ancient cosmological and theological debate allows us to focus less on how reality was born, avoiding the questions before the film, and examine what exactly engenders it to continue; Aquinas viewed god as a transcendent force of goodness, knowledge, happiness, love, and who is to say "transcendent force" should be objectively defined in an age of god-like scientific discoveries and knowledge.

The commentary on all these dimensions is centered around the main protagonist; Capa achieves direct communion with god, so to speak, because he is the right hybrid of ethics, faith, reason, intellect, ideology. He, like Daedalus in the myth, navigates knowledge with grace, in order to fly at just the right distance from the Sun, and evokes an ideological support of knowledge and metaphysics when he says "very little will happen at first -and then a spark, will pop into existence, and it will hang for an instant, hovering in space and then, it will split into two, and those will split again, and again, and again - detonation beyond all imaging, he big bang on a small scale. A new

star born out of a dying one. I think it will be beautiful.” This becomes the defining moment of his existence: his ability to face a scenario that has plagued his nightmares, with no ego, making massive, untested leaps of science (using an unfathomable weapon of mass destruction) in the name of love and the future of civilization. Ultimately he does not become god or suffer his own intellectual arrogance, but allows himself to be the instrument of transmission for a miracle of science. As he witnesses the experimental atomic payload come alive, he is bathed in the same inferno that once haunted his nightmares; however, this time he is visibly at peace, allowing himself to be consumed by the knowledge (or faith) that he was successful, allowing us to see evidence of god in science.

Through a lens of Greek mythology, philosophical history, and modes of morality, a superficially stunning vista of our inner solar system becomes a more profound story of man’s relationship to the metaphysical – since the atomic era, we have pushed the moral and spiritual boundaries of science, blurring the lines so that “science is a system of belief, technology a mode of action whose purpose is to overcome man’s physical inadequacies”⁶. With that comes ethical lines of inquest, strings that unravel contextually into spiritual and philosophical examination, alongside a faith-based examination of ego, hubris, and man’s capacity for playing god, identifying god, and worshipping god. While this film was released several decades after more overt commentary on the nuclear age, its central purpose seems to comment on the recursiveness of philosophical inquiry and the inevitable perpetuity of ethical and spiritual re-examination and revision of science and civilization. This film pivots from the old nuclear age, in which science is no longer inherently innocent and its purpose and use must be questioned or restrained, to explore the invisible boundaries between man and god, lest man fly too close to the Sun and crash.

⁶ Sobchack, Vivian Carol. Sobchack. Screening Space : the American Science Fiction Film. p. 62

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